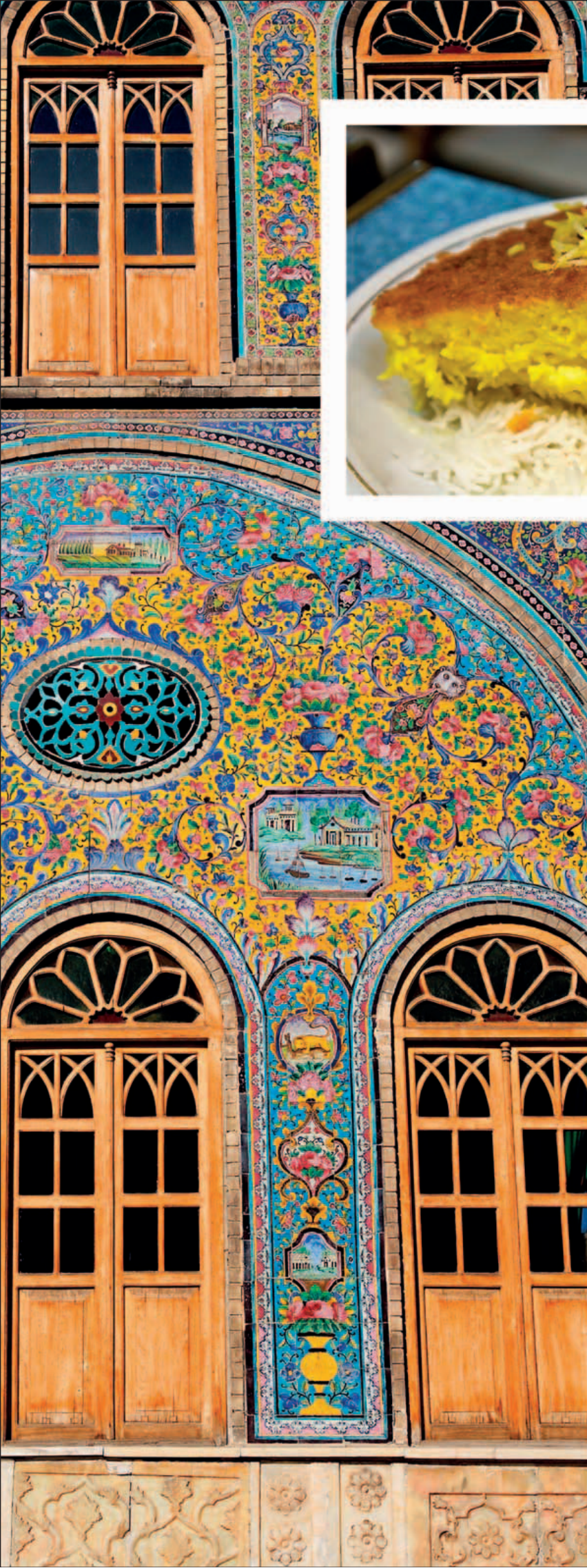




Above The highly prized golden crust of *tachin polo* is achieved by slowly baking the cooked, layered rice and chicken in a buttered pan

Left The Golestan Palace was part of a group of royal buildings built within the mud-thatched walls of Tehran's historic *arg*, or citadel



Above Specialty rice dishes are always an important part of Iranian festivities, such as Yalda – the longest night of the year

A Celebratory Dish

Of the many delicious variations of *polo*, *tachin* is the best and most elaborate. Here the partly cooked rice is mixed with yogurt and saffron, and used to coat the inside of a heavy pan. The center is then filled with alternating layers of rice and chicken mixed with *zerezhk* (barberries) before the whole dish is slowly baked until the outer surface forms a delicious golden crust. It is then turned out on to a plate. *Tachin* are sometimes seen stacked one on top of another, like the tiers of a wedding cake. It is not the sort of dish you find everywhere, and is typically made for festive occasions, but you have more chance of finding it in Tehran than anywhere else.

The Best Places to Eat Polo

The Khayyam Traditional Restaurant moderate

The Khayyam Traditional Restaurant, right in the heart of Tehran's frenetic bazaar near the Nasreddin mosque, is one of the most beautifully decorated traditional restaurants in the Iranian capital. The historic building (originally part of the Nasreddin mosque complex) was recently restored, and now has a main area with wooden tables and chairs as well as partly enclosed areas with cushions for seating. Its brick-vaulted interior is moodily lit, highlighting the decorative mosaic tiles. It can (and does) get extremely busy, particularly at lunch times, but the atmosphere always remains friendly and relaxed. The menu ranges from succulent kebabs served alongside a mountain of fragrant *chelo* rice to steaming plates of *khoresh* (see pp164–5), *abgusht*, or *dizi* (meat stews) and, of course, *polo* dishes, including *zerezhk polo* served with the requisite wedge of butter. Portions are generous and the prices, while more than average for Iran, are still very reasonable.

Khayyam Street, Tehran; open 11 AM–11 PM daily; +98 21 5580 0760

Also in Tehran

The busy **Ferdosi Sonnati** (+98 21 6671 4503; *inexpensive*), at the southern end of Ferdosi Street, serves plenty of traditional Persian dishes, including *zerezhk polo* and *tachin*. Other good options are **Sofreh Khane Ayyaran** (+98 21 6676 0376; *moderate*), which is sometimes inundated by tour groups but does serve a wider-than-average range of traditional Persian dishes, and the buzzing subterranean **Sofreh Khane Ali Ghapoo** (+98 21 8877 7803; *inexpensive*).

Also in Iran

In Isfahan, *tachin* is served at **Nobahar** (+98 311 221 0800; *inexpensive*) and **Shahrzad** (+98 311 220 4490; *moderate*). The **Khan Gostar Restaurant** (+98 311 627 8989; *moderate*) in the Hotel Julfa, Isfahan, is another excellent choice, and very popular with locals.

Around the World

There are many Persian restaurants in London, but the contemporary-styled **Lavash** (www.lavash.co.uk; *moderate*) at the top of Finchley Road is one of the few that serve *tachin*. **Little Persia** (www.littlepersia.co.uk; *moderate*) serves several *polo* dishes in its colorful interior, and **Alounak** (www.alounak.co.uk; *moderate*) is another longstanding favorite in the UK capital.